

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*When Things Fall Apart
Heart Advice for Difficult Times
How to...Cope with Disaster
June 29th, 2025*



Photographer Unknown

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Emma Whitten, *Guest Organist*

Prelude and Fugue in G minor, Op. 7, No. 3 - Marcel Dupré (1886–1971)
Vater unser im Himmelreich - Georg Böhm (1661–1733)
Vater unser im Himmelreich, BWV 683 - Johann Sebastian Bach (1685–1750)
Chant de Paix - Jean Langlais (1907–1991)
Cortège et Litanie, Op. 19, No. 2 - Marcel Dupré (1886–1971)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Words of Gathering

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Russell Alexander-Orozco

This morning as we gather in gratitude,
let us be open to the chaos of life:
detentions and deportations,
inflation and tariffs,
wars and rumors of wars,
and the tearing...of the fabric of our very lives.

This morning, let us also be open
to the wonder of things:
the magnificent and marvelous pattern
of life at its best when we rise together,
the beauty that is beyond
our minds to comprehend
but not to be apprehended by,
the goodness of strangers,
and the outpouring of help
even in the midst of fear.

Today, we must gather all our collective energy
to celebrate that even in the midst of these days
we are held by an order that emerges from the chaos,
and by a chaos that reveals suffocating structures.

Together, let us learn that within this cacophony of Order and Chaos
the Spirit is calling us to dance - into an unknown future
guarded and guided by the light of the One,
who shows us the way.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Praise with Joy the World's Creator

LAUDA ANIMA

Praise with joy the world's creator,
God of justice, love, and peace,
Source and end of human knowledge,
Grace bestowing without cease.
Celebrate the Maker's glory,
Power to rescue and release.

Praise the Christ who feeds the hungry,
Frees the captive, finds the lost,
Heals the sick, upends religion,
Fearless both of fate and cost.
Celebrate Christ's constant presence-
Friend and Stranger, Guest and Host.

Praise the Spirit sent among us,
Liberating truth from pride,
Forging bonds where race or gender,
Age or nation dare divide.
Celebrate the Spirit's treasure -
Foolishness none dare deride.

Praise the Maker, Christ, and Spirit,
One God in Community.
Calling People to embody
Oneness and diversity.
Thus the world shall yet believe
When shown Christ's vibrant unity.
- The Iona Community

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

O Holy One,
we gather, listening for a word
that is trustworthy and true;
for we have had our fill of worthless words,
slick and smooth,
politic and pleasing,
euphemisms and truisms,
none that allow us to open our hearts
and help us find the way to realize
a new Heaven and a new Earth.

So we ask - that you would string together, here, this morning,
the words we need that tie our lives to hope -
as they help us to believe that you do in fact dwell with dreamers
who trust that even now you are fashioning -
from tears and terror -
a transformed world
where the homeless find shelter
and the heartless find love.

*Help us, Holy One, to hear the resonant voice
declaring words of wonder;
that crying and pain will be no more,
that your kin-dom,
eternally present and yet always coming,
is being birthed
through the words of poets, and prophets,
and the likes of us,
announcing that your dwelling place
has been and always will be with each one of us
and with all our siblings, who dare to dream.*

On this day, may it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"Liberty and Justice For All"
Cathedral Choir

BRANDON WILLIAMS

***The Lord's Prayer**

Russell Alexander-Orozco

*Our God, who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

For mighty winds that swept across the seas
and your mighty Spirit that disturbs the waters of life,
thanks be to you, O God.

For the spirit of freedom that stirs our passions
and the longings for liberty that surge from human depths,
thanks be to you.

Within us, between us, and among us in our world
hear the cry of the earth's bound people.

*Within us, between us, and among us, O God,
hear earth's cry for liberty.*

This morning, may the Peace and Freedom of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Readings from the Wisdom of Our Tradition
From Psalm 16

Russell Alexander-Orozco

For these words of the ancients whose wisdom we welcome in our present,
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayers of Our Hearts

Eternal Mystery, Heaven's Presence,
Stillest Breath and Deepest Sigh,
we open our hearts
to the presence of who we are in this time.

Each of us brings life to this day's possibilities.
We bring hope or despair
eagerness or malaise,
joy or sorrow,
and with these things
we gather together.

On this day, may the weight of sorrow
unfold in our bodies
that we may allow your arms,
and the arms of our siblings,
to hold us in this sacred time.

On this day, may the beauty of life's fullness
unfold in our hearts that we may loosen
the grip of the unknown on our lives.

On this day, may the richness of mystery
unfold in our minds
that we may let go of our need for certainty.

On this day, may the possibility
of newness and light be present to us
that we may unfold the wings of our faith,
and soar into the world changed by your possibilities
and our work for justice.

May we see in this time together,
the collective beauty of this world
in all our diversity,
and may we stand together committed
to changing this world
amid the miracle of the presence of the Divine,
and our presence, in it.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"Sicut Cervus"
Laude

GIOVANNI DA PALESTRINA

"My soul thirsts for the living God: When shall I come and appear before the face of God?" ~Psalm 42:1

Sermon

How to...Cope with Disaster

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

That peace
Will rise like bread
We can always hope.

That justice
Will flow like wine
We can always hope.

That the table
Will make strangers kin
We can always hope.

That our hope
Will rise like bread
We can always pray.

[janrichardson]

Prayer of Blessing

Rev. Tanaka Pack

We thank you God,
for the bread and the cup,
for the life and the Love,
for the Wisdom to walk in your world.

Help us to share the love, strength, and faith
we find at this table.

*Help us to accept these same things when
others share it with us
that we might change the world together.*

We pray this in the Strong Name
of the One we follow.
Amen and Amen!

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Panis Angelicus"
Tiffany Ho, Soloist

CESAR FRANK

*"The angel's bread becomes the bread for all. The heavenly bread unites;
Oh, miraculous thing! The bread of love nourishes the humble seeker."*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Russell Alexander-Orozco

Holy One of Many Names,
may these gifts be used
to bring comfort and courage,
hope and love
to all your children.

Help us to not lose heart in these days,
even as we live and move and have our being
in the midst of the harshness of life.

Give us strength, O God, to work together
to end the violence and suffering
that plague your many children
in our city, in our countries, and in our world.

*On this day, may we work
for peace and justice
and may our prayers*

*be not only on our lips,
but in our lives.
Amen and Amen!*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

Go into this day in faith.
And may each day in the coming weeks,
be born of God,
may each hour be a journey with the Christ
and may each moment be filled
with the life and grace of the Spirit.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"World Peace Prayer"
Cathedral Choir

MARTY HAUGEN, arr. DAVID HARRIS

***Hymn for the Journey**

Come Now, O Wisdom

SLANE

Come now, O Wisdom; we need your clear voice;
Speak and awaken our hearts to rejoice.
Gracious Creator of more than we know,
In your own image may we ever grow.

Come now, O Wisdom; abide in our souls;
Stir in us visions of life free and whole.
Wisdom, our pathway to justice and peace,
With you our dreams find their fullest release.

Wisdom, more precious than rubies or gold,
With you our graces forever unfold.
No fame or fortune with you can compare;
Pour out your blessings, so rich and so rare.

Wisdom, your grace joins all heaven and earth;
With you we labor, new life to give birth.
Come now, O Wisdom, our Midwife and Friend;
Open our hearts to your world without end. [Jann Aldredge-Clanton]

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Emma Whitten, Guest Organist

Wir glauben all an einen Gott, BWV 680 - Johann Sebastian Bach (1685–1750)

Inside The Music

“The opening line of Psalm 42 that Palestrina set to music reveals God in the natural world and illuminates our role in the divine relationship. Palestrina was one of the most celebrated musicians of the 16th century, and has remained an icon of Renaissance polyphony. He set “Sicut Cervus” near the end of his life. This motet in two parts is considered one of a handful of pieces that represent the apex of the Italian Renaissance. The sheer balance that he is able to achieve using a lifetime of mastery in polyphonic (many voice) writing staggers the mind. Like so many masterworks, it is distinctly approachable. Because Palestrina was such a master, he was able to create concentrated, accessible beauty from complexity. He musically answers the poem’s longing by portraying the divine in music. In his time, emotional character in music was understood largely through melodic content. The mode of the piece helped to define how melodies behaved. Palestrina chose the often pastoral Ionian mode. The first five notes of the scale, when heard in sequence, communicated strength and clarity to a Renaissance listener. Over the course of the opening phrase, Palestrina rises across the first five notes. He does so, though, in a meandering way that rises a little, then falls before rising again, and only eventually making it to the fifth note. In this gesture he reveals the flowing water metaphor in the Psalm. The water metaphor explores the meandering emotional path that we humans take in times of chaos. The rest of the piece continues to illuminate the dialogue of the deer (humanity) and the water (divine) in ways that bring them closer together in a satisfying dance. In the second part, Palestrina flips the melody. Instead of moving upward over the first five notes, he moves downward over the last four notes. This part of the scale was considered important as well, if secondary to the first five notes. It almost always communicated a separate, often opposite, emotional quality to the first five notes. In the second part comes the question “when will I appear before the face of God.” The musical choice is a softening, a questioning. It destabilizes the picturesque flow of the first part while strengthening the relationship with the divine. All throughout the piece, Palestrina positions the fourth scale degree (C in a G Ionian mode) as a deific presence in the music. As the second part winds its way through the questioning part of the scale, Palestrina brings us closer and closer to that C representation of the divine. Even as the words ask about the divine’s presence, the music affirms that God is all around and through everything. A master at the end of his life, Palestrina gave us the gift of his art, searching, struggle and vulnerability, and his faith that no matter what happens, we are surrounded by the divine.” – Dr. David Harris